



Making a case: Rumours surrounding Ayyoub Bouaddi gathered pace throughout Morocco's 2026 World Cup campaign as the teenage midfielder outshone several established stars on football's biggest stage. AFP

accepted Aston Villa's proposal, attracted by the lure of Champions League football.

Manzambi was already earmarked as one of the talents to watch, and he made full use of the World Cup stage to underline his potential. Despite a curtailed tournament because of injury, the attacking midfielder tallied three goals and two assists to help Switzerland progress deep into the knockout rounds.

Another starlet who drew plenty of interest was Ivory Coast winger

Yan Diomande. His goal and assist numbers do not fully reflect his performances at the tournament. The RB Leipzig winger was a constant threat on the left flank, repeatedly beating opposing full-backs with his dribbling.

He completed 2.7 dribbles per game and recorded an Expected Assists (xA) figure of 0.49, the seventh-best in the World Cup. While pre-tournament reports suggested he could join Liverpool, more recent reports say reigning Champions League winner Paris Saint-Germain is looking to add him to its roster.

Moroccan magic

Morocco's 18-year-old Ayyoub Bouaddi has been linked with a 100-million-euro move to Manchester City, according to reports in England.

The midfielder started five of Morocco's six games and was the second-youngest player behind Pele to feature in a World Cup quarterfinal. The youngster came through Lille's academy and has made 96 appearances since his debut in 2023.

He made his senior international debut just weeks before the World Cup, having previously represented France at the youth level. His technical ability could see him become a long-term replacement for Bernardo Silva at City.

Azzedine Ounahi could be another Moroccan looking to climb further up the football ladder. The lanky midfielder, who burst onto the scene at the 2022 World Cup, once again stamped his class in the middle of the park.

Although his greatest strength lies in his playmaking, the